



Ahead of the best: The throw lifts Dehning over Olympic Champion Neeraj and European champion Julian Weber — neither of whom have touched the 90m mark in their career so far.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

erasing, by nearly four metres, the one set by reigning Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra back in 2016.

Dehning says he didn't come into the competition expecting to do as well as he did. Indeed, he is the only javelin thrower in history to have made a 90m throw before making an 80m one. His 90.20m throw came in his very first attempt, followed by 85.22m in his second.

"People are asking me what I ate before the competition, but the truth is that I just had the hotel buffet. I didn't set myself any real goals before the competition. I just wanted to see where I was in terms of performance and whether the training was working," he tells *Sportstar*.

"I actually only realised (I had crossed 90m) when it was on the scoreboard. I realised when I threw it that it was a really long throw. But I didn't expect this throw to fly 90m. I hadn't really realised this result yet!" he says.

A few days later, he's still coming to grips with his achievement. "I think throwing 90m is something very special, something very magical... I can't really comment on this throw at the moment, it's taken my breath away. I think my life has been turned upside down because suddenly this makes me one of the best javelin throwers in the world," he says.

Olympic prospect

The throw lifts Dehning over Olympic Champion Neeraj and European champion Julian Weber — neither of whom have touched the 90m mark in their career so far. And while it's still early in the season, Dehning, who has now qualified for the Olympics and can now be counted as one of the contenders in Paris, insists he isn't thinking that far ahead.

"I'm not putting any pressure on myself! I will try to prove myself in the men's field and

achieve the best possible result. I'm not thinking about the fact (that I'm ahead of the other throwers). What worked for me in Halle was that I managed to stay relaxed in the competition and not put any pressure on myself. Technically, everything went well together after that," he says.

Should Dehning go on to live up to the expectations that many will be placing on him now, he will find himself in illustrious company. Germany has had no shortage of icons in the 90m club of men's javelin throw. Think yesteryear champion Uwe Hohn (the only one ever to breach the 100m mark; in 1984) as well as Thomas Rohler (champion in 2016), Johannes Vetter and Andreas Hofmann in recent years.

While Germany might hope Dehning brings the roof down at the Stade de France in half a year's time, he's equally comfortable building one himself. When he isn't breaking records on the athletics field, he's most likely to be found putting together a roof.

"Dad has his own carpentry and timber construction company. And mom is also a construction technician. I'm also very interested in crafts and therefore like to spend my free time on the building site," he says.

While he hopes to follow his parents into the construction business one day, growing up in Leverkusen, he was also inspired by them to follow a passion for sports.

His parents were both athletes — father Sascha Dehning played handball at the club level — while his sister Marie won bronze in the heptathlon at the European Junior Championships.

"Sport has played an important role in our family from the very beginning. My father played handball at a very high level and my mother has always been involved in both athletics and swimming," he says.

Handball to javelin

Dehning started by taking after his father in handball, before switching to track and field. He competed in both shot put and 400m before focussing on javelin.

"I would say that I am very good in multiple disciplines of athletics and would generally like to try my hand in more of them. I am still very interested in handball, as I used to play it myself. Nevertheless, I was born to throw the javelin! I was influenced by it from an early age. All I ever wanted to do was throw, throw and throw," he says.

"I started throwing the baton as a little kid and then it was a smooth transition to javelin — starting with the 400-gram javelin and

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